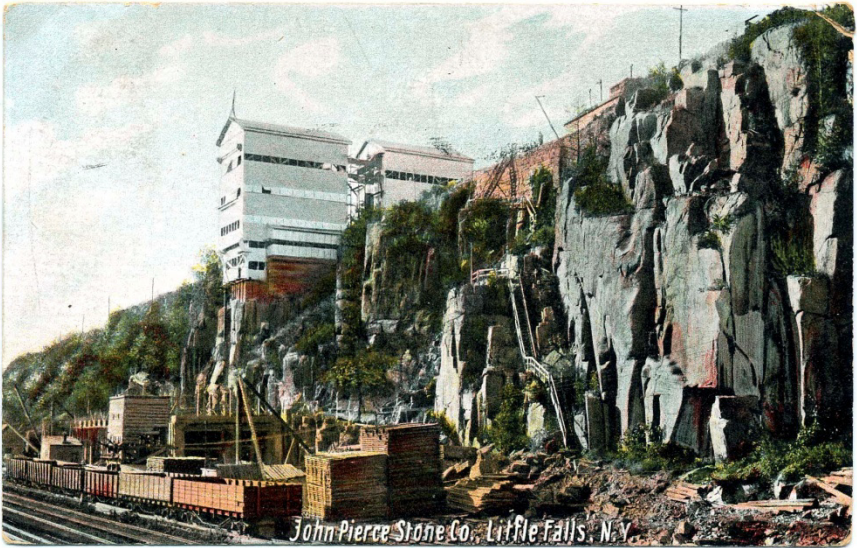


Rock Climbing Guide to the Little Falls Railroad Track Craggs



by

Gary Thomann
Geoffrey Childs
Singletrack Publishing
2010

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Cover Illustration

Wish you were here! A postcard of the John Pierce Stone factory. It opened in 1921 and closed in 1930. The remains are still visible today. It produced crushed stone; I assume the rock source was the quarry north of the plant on the other side of Highway 5. Can you identify any of the walls/climbs?

All photos by Gary Thomann unless otherwise noted

Corrections, additions should be sent to
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Notes to the Reader

Rock Climbing is a dangerous activity; you can be hurt or killed while practicing it. I make no assertions that the routes described here are safe, or that any hardware installed on the cliffs is safe. Any climbing decisions are entirely yours.

The railroad track crags on the north side of the Mohawk River are on private property. From the property records it is difficult if not impossible to determine who owns or controls access to some of the cliffs. There is no written or oral agreement with the owner(s) allowing public use of the cliffs; you must obtain permission to climb. You may be denied access to the cliffs at any time. This guidebook in no way implies that you have a right to access to the cliffs or to climb on them.

Hardware (bolts and belay anchors) exists on some of the railroad track cliffs. There is no certification that this hardware was properly installed or that it has not been tampered with. In the past, hardware has been damaged or removed at Little Falls cliffs, and recently hardware at other climbing sites in New York has been damaged. The inspection and use of any hardware is entirely your own responsibility.

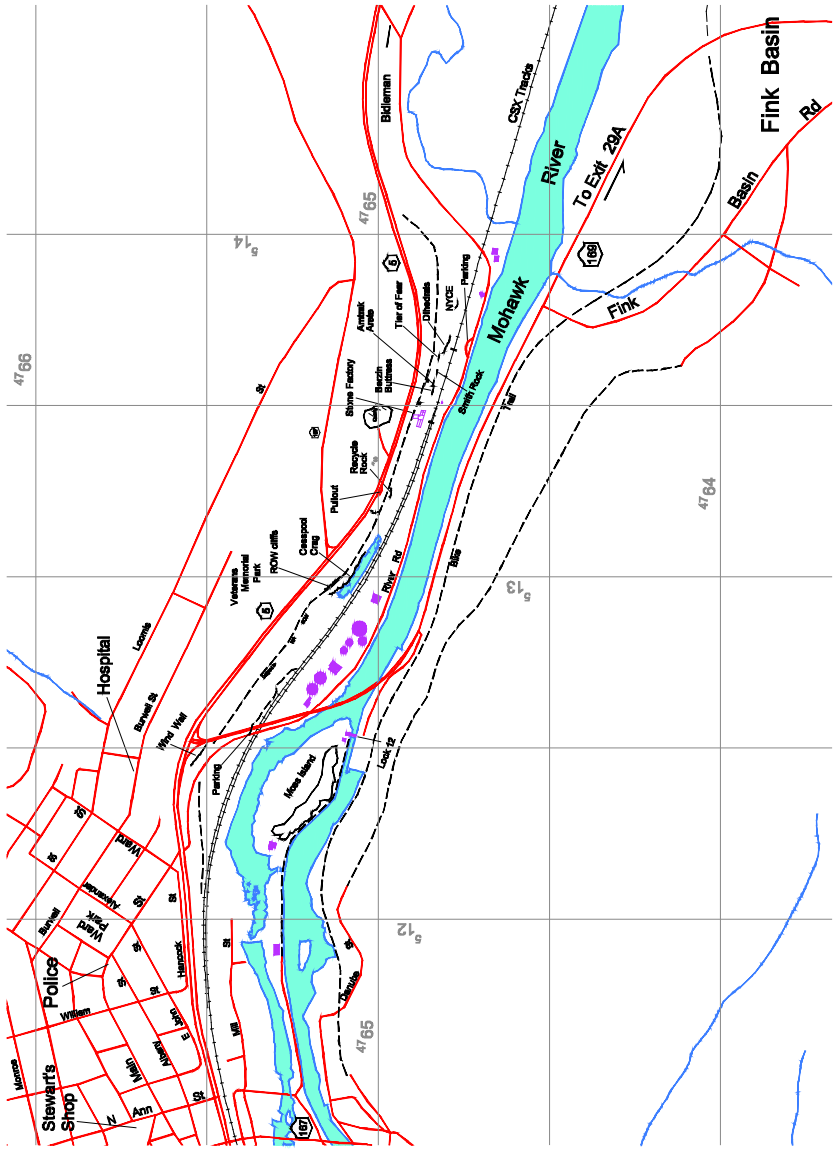


Figure 1. Map of the area. Grid is .5 km square, set GPS to UTM, NAD83, Zone 18, distance in meters.

Introduction

There are numerous cliffs along the Mohawk River in the village of Little Falls. They exist because of a fortunate combination of mountain building, faulting, glaciers and the Mohawk River – I won't go into that at the moment. Some of the cliffs are on Moss Island, "owned" by the NYS Canal Corporation (a division of the Thruway Authority). According to some written or unwritten agreement, the Village of Little Falls administers Moss Island; to climb there you must purchase a daily permit at the police department; I believe the current fee is \$3. The Moss Island cliffs are covered in a separate guide.

On the north side of the Mohawk River, are a series of south facing cliffs from 30 to 70 ft high. The formation at the western end, just across from Moss Island is the Wind Wall. At the eastern end, about a mile downstream, is the Dihedrals. Each of the other cliffs in the series is also named. The map in Figure 1 on the proceeding page shows the general layout. The ownership of these cliffs is complicated. There is a large privately owned parcel and many of the cliffs are clearly on this parcel; on others the cliff face seems to set right on the border between the private parcel and land owned by other organizations. Some of the other organizations owning land are CSX Railroad, City of Little Falls and the State of New York. The NYS owned land is mostly along the edge of highway 5, which runs east/west along the top of the cliffs. Another complication is that some of the land is within the city limits of Little Falls, while other parts are in the Town of Manheim. In the past climbers were much more likely to be tossed off cliffs within Little Falls than they were those in Manheim. If you climb on any cliffs in the privately owned parcel you need the owners permission.

To get to the north side crags, for most people the easiest way is off the Thruway (I90) at Exit 29A, and north on highway 169. As the highway angles left to go along the Mohawk River you can look across and see the Dihedrals and just west of them the old stone factory. Continue on 169 past the turnoff for Moss Island and cross the river to the T at highway 5. For the Wind Wall, or, or for an approach to the other cliffs from the west, turn left onto highway 5, drive a few hundred feet and turn left again onto River Rd, which angles back east past the base of the Wind Wall. It is best not to park in front of the wall (don't attract attention). Instead drive on down the slope and park under the bridge. Walk back up River Rd to the west end of the wall, there is a path here. To get to the other crags from this parking spot just walk east along the CSX tracks.

To access the cliffs from the east end, at the T intersection turn right on highway 5, go east past the highway 167 turnoff and then turn right on Bidleman Rd. At the bottom of Bidleman Rd angle right onto River Rd, drive under the railroad bridge and turn into the parking lot on the right (north side) just a few hundred feet past the bridge. From the parking lot walk north over the railroad tracks right where the signaling structure; you will be in front of the Dihedrals.

There is a third access point. When on Highway 5, instead of going all the way to Bidleman Rd, park in the small overlook lot on the right side of the

highway, just a few hundred yards past the 167 turnoff. This overlook is directly above Recycle Rock. However, it best not to try to jump directly from the highway to the top of the cliff. Instead, walk back west along highway 5 for about 60 m (200 ft) and turn left onto a path. This path first goes right, then angles back left and drops to the old Dolgeville Railroad ROW. From here you can turn east to go to Recycle Rock and the other eastern cliffs or turn right for the cesspool cliffs.

This guide is an update of the original 1990 guide by Geoffrey Childs. For trad climbs the G, PG, R, X rating system is used for the updated guide.

History

This area is so soaked in history the challenge will be to stay with the events that influence the rock climbing. A convenient place to begin is with the Grenville orogeny (mountain building) and erosion about 1 billion years ago that established the hard basement rock underlying most of the east coast of North America. In most places the basement rock is covered by younger deposits; a notable exception is the Adirondack mountains, where a recent landform rise has resulted in the overlying deposits being stripped off.

Fast forward to about 450 million years ago when the Taconic orogeny was happening. A more or less north/south fault developed through Little Falls with a vertical displacement of nearly a thousand feet across the fault - higher in the west and lower in the east. On the west side this brought the hard Grenville basement rock up into contact with the softer overlying rock on the east. Again skip the details for a while and move to the end of the last glacial period about 11,000 years ago. Lake Iroquois, to the west of Little Falls, started draining through the Iro-Mohawk River, and in the process carved a canyon several hundred feet deep through the basement rock on the west side of the fault. The result can be seen today – the intricate carvings on Moss Island, a bore hole you can crawl through on the north shore, and I guess the rounded cliffs on the face of the Dihedrals.

Although 11,000 years is a very short time geologically, it is still long enough that no pictures survive showing what the cliffs looked like when the river receded and became the plain old Mohawk. The oldest thing I have been able to find is a painting made from the vantage point of Fincks (Finks) suspension bridge that crossed the Mohawk a bit downstream of the cliffs. It is shown in Figure 2. The quality of the image is not real good, but it is still interesting. The Erie Canal is on the left; the north shore cliffs on the right. There does not appear to be a railroad along the north shore (later we will see this means the painting is pre 1836). Also there seem to be some cliffs close to the shore. Of course this is a painting, so artistic license is involved.

Did any of man's activities in the succeeding years insult the cliffs? To try to answer that we probably need to consider, in more or less historical order, the Erie Canal, the CSX Railroad, the Dolgeville Railroad, the John Pierce Stone Company, the 1940 train wreck, the Wind Bridge, the cesspool pond and the recent train wreck.



Figure 2. Pre 1836 view of the north shore cliffs from downstream.

The Erie Canal

There were actually a series of Erie Canals. The first was started on July 4, 1817 and completed on October 26, 1825, sarcastically named "Clinton's Big Ditch." Four feet deep, 40 ft wide, 83 locks with a 568 ft rise from the Hudson River to Lake Erie. It was enlarged between 1836 and 1862 to be 70 ft wide and 7 ft deep; the number of locks reduced to 72. Most remaining traces of the old canal are from this second era. The canal was again enlarged between 1903 and 1918 to 120 to 200 ft in width, 12 to 14 ft deep, 363 miles long from Albany to Buffalo. There are 57 locks with lifts from 6 to 40 feet. This is the canal you see today.

If you climb at Moss Island, as you walk from the parking lot you can see the south half of Lock 36 from the 1836 to 1862 period. The north half of this lock was destroyed when the present lock (E-17) was constructed. I guess it is impossible to prove that the construction of Lock 36 (or the earlier canal) had no effect on the cliffs. However, since the lock is on the south side of the river, I am going to guess that neither of the first two canals had any effect on the cliffs on the north side of the river.

The construction of the modern Lock 17 at Little Falls was finished in 1916. The postcard below in Figure 3 shows some of the trash piled up around the lock during construction. I expect this had some effect on the Moss Island cliffs, but again I am going to say none on the cliffs north of the river. If you look closely at the postcard you may be able to see that the island extends quite a ways to the north. I mention this because it will be discussed later.



Figure 3. Postcard of Lock 17 with fill piled at east end

The Railroads

The CSX railroad tracks fit rather neatly between the Mohawk River and the north side cliffs, and you have to wonder what was done to make the ROW level enough for tracks. Of course the railroad wasn't always CSX, it became that in 1998. Before that it was Conrail (since 1976), Penn Central (1968) and New York Central (1853). New York Central (NYC) in turn was formed from several smaller companies. The first tracks along the north shore of the Mohawk going through Little Falls were laid by the Utica and Schenectady Railroad Company; the track opened in 1836. Since the first practical use of photography developed about 1839 we are probably not going to find any photos of the construction. The first railroad was obviously a single track; later photos of the NYC show four tracks (there are two tracks today). However, I have not been able to find any evidence (other than our painting) that the cliffs were altered during the original construction or modifications later.

The line that did effect the north side cliffs was the Little Falls Dolgeville Railroad, a short (10 ¼ mile) route between the two cities. It opened in 1892, Near where it started in Little Falls it appears to have gone right next to the Wind Wall. Perhaps the right-of-way (ROW) was blasted out, creating the Wind Wall. The postcard below in Figure 4 confused me for a long time, because of the relative positions of the two railroads and the river. The view is looking east, the Little Falls Dolgeville line is on the left and I am going to guess that the cliff on the left is the Wind Wall. The confusing part is that this view does not exist today. We will get back to that in a minute, but first lets finish with the Dolgeville line.



Figure 4. View of Dolgeville line and New York Central by Wind Wall?

Going east from the Wind Wall the Dolgeville line climbed until it ran along the top of the Cesspool Cliffs, Recycle Rock,, and the Dihedrals. The postcard below in Figure 5 shows a section of the ROW above the cliffs (you are looking west). Considering the amount of fill used and possible blasting it seems certain the cliffs were affected.

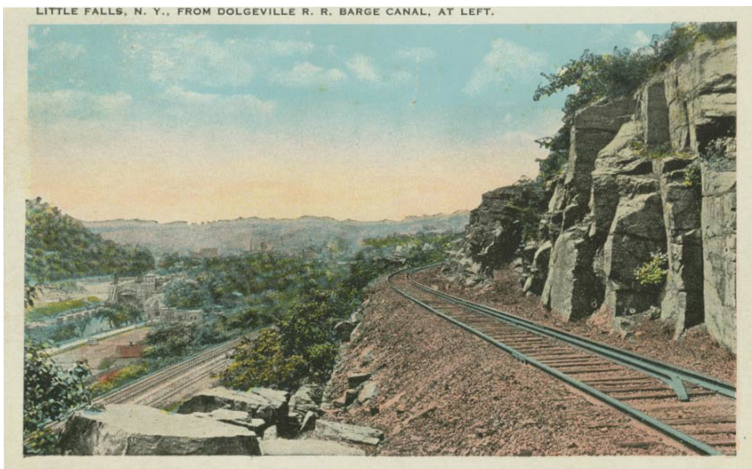


Figure 5. Looking west along the Little Falls Dolgeville Railroad.

The Gulf Curve Wreck

Now return to the view in Figure 4 and the confusion. As you can see, the Dolgeville line is being forced up against the Wind Wall by the NYC tracks. However, these NYC tracks no longer exist today. In the postcard, the locomotive on the NYC tracks, going west, was about to enter the (infamous) gulf curve, on which the speed limit was 45 mi/hr. That speed limit had been imposed after a 1903 accident on the curve.

On the evening of April 19, 1940 Train No. 19, the Lake Shore Limited passenger train pulled by Engine No. 5315 tried to take this curve at 59 mi/hr. Although there is some evidence that the speed limit was often ignored, it was fatal in this case. Just past the Wind Wall, the engine and several cars went off the track and into a rock embankment on the right. 31 people were killed and 51 injured. As a result, the railroad decided to straighten the curve. There was a slight delay for WWII and then the massive project began. First a new river channel had to be blasted right through the north end of Moss Island and the old channel filled in. The CSX tracks now run across what was the northern edge of the island. If you look at the location map in the Introduction, it looks like the river right across from the Wind Wall has been shaved off. In fact yes it has been and the CSX track has been moved, and that is the reason the postcard in Figure 4 doesn't look like anything that exists today. I don't know if this work had any effect on the Moss Island cliffs. I do know that if you canoe around the north edge of the present island you are looking at what the project left, not what was originally sculpted by the river.

The fascinating image shown in Figure 6 is an aerial photo of the track straightening project; it must have been taken in 1947/48. The scan of the original photo was not very good, but I have not been able to obtain the photo so it could be rescanned. The north end of Moss Island has been removed. Part of the old river channel is still visible, as is the old NYC ROW. The Dolgeville track going by the Wind Wall is visible and I think (am I imagining things), I can see Alfreds Overhang.

The John Pierce Stone Company

The next possible culprit to be considered is the John Pierce Stone Company, conveniently pictured on the cover of this guide. The plant was completed in 1921 and only lasted until 1930, when it was closed and abandoned, decaying away to the present shell. It must have been an expensive structure to build. There was competition from another stone company immediately across the river, with the result that neither survived for long. The postcard appears to be during the latter part of construction. Since there appear to be no photographs of the factory area before construction started, we will probably never know if any high quality cliffs were destroyed. However it seems almost certain that at least a few good climbs were removed.

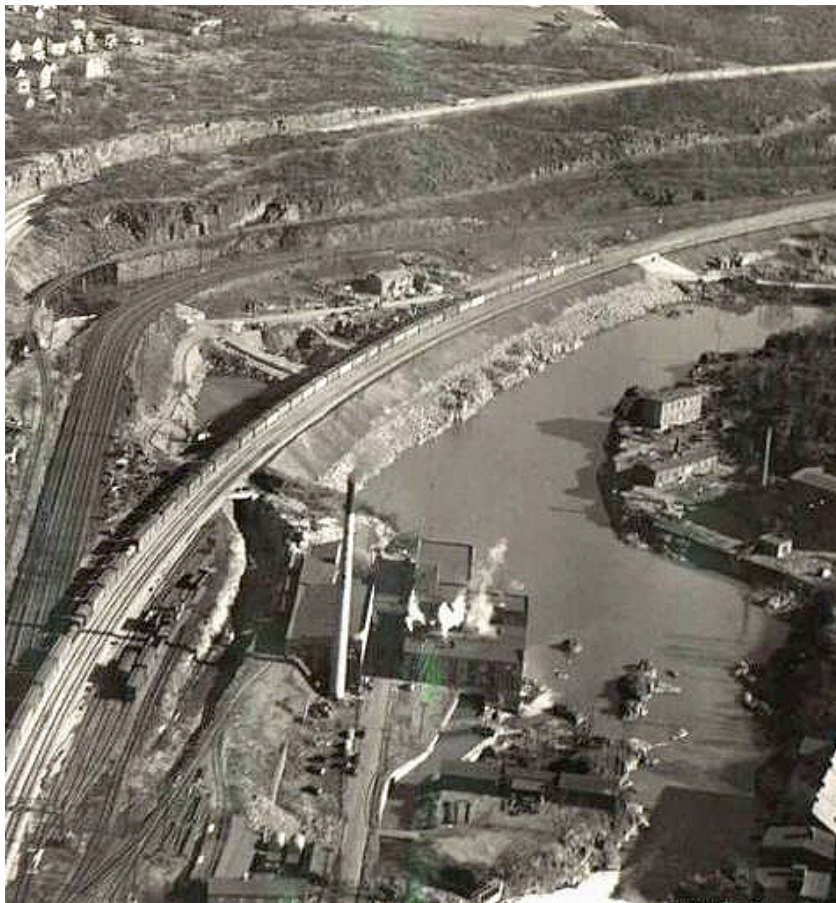


Figure 6. Aerial view of the NYC Gulf Curve track straightening.

The Highway 169 Wind Bridge

Next in line is the Highway 169 Wind Bridge over the Mohawk. In 1974 the NYS Thruway (or Dept of Trans) tried to build the Wind Bridge right across Moss Island; you can imagine the damage the construction and the supports could have done to the island cliffs. Apparently they were stopped by two activists from Albany, Paul Stewart and Daniel Van Riper's wife (for you feminists [bless you!] I want to say that I couldn't find her first name and had to write it that way- Mr. Riper refers to her that way in his column). If the bridge had been built as originally intended the north end of the bridge may have destroyed the Wind Wall. As constructed, the bridge north end rests just east of the Wind Wall; I do not know if any climbs existed there.

The Green Pond

The next feature we will consider is Green Pond or the cesspool pond, as it is sometimes referred to, a long narrow pond between the CSX railroad and the cliffs that blocks access. The pond effectively closes off several hundred feet of the cliff. It is apparently due to drainage from the north and is kept at a constant level by a drain pipe, which passes under the CSX tracks to the Mohawk River. There is some evidence that the pond has not always existed; according to personal communication with Lucinda Parker (author of "Little Falls and Dolgeville Railroad," 2005) the area was dry until construction started on the Highway 167 intersection on Highway 5 just north of the cliffs. Perhaps blasting open a crack that changed the drainage and created the pond. I have not been able to obtain any information about when the construction was done.

The 2004 Train Wreck

On October 30, 2004, 25 cars of a CSX train derailed in the Berzins Buttress/Dihedrals area. No damage was done to the cliffs (one freight car was resting against the cliff near Smith Rock but did not mar it). The cars remained for several months and generally were a nuisance to climbing. They were finally cut up and removed. As part of the cleanup process a small stream was moved closer to the cliffs and some trees that partially shielded the Dihedrals were removed. A photo is shown in Figure 7.



Figure 7. The Oct 30 2004 train derailment (cars since removed).

Climbing History

The earliest rock climbing in the area appears to have been during the 1950's by members of the Syracuse Outing Club, GE Outing Club, AMC and other climbers from the area. Ed Bielejec started climbing at Moss Island in 1954. In 1969, after returning from the service, Ed started climbing along the north shore, doing most routes on aid. Along with Fran Combar and other partners he cleaned out some of the cliffs and established many good lines.

Between 1974 and 1978, R.L. Stolz, Woody Carrell, Andy Gillespie and others established most of the lines on Moss Island. In those days you could drive onto the island and camp, so they would spend all weekend climbing. About the same time Christophe Davis began climbing at the Dihedrals. Ron Randall arrived in 1978 and along with Dale Skibinski, Jeff George and Davis spent the next five years climbing the cliffs on the north shore, setting a 5.11 standard. Somewhere along here Geoffrey Childs arrived, and in 1988 Martin Berzins, already a well known British climber of high skill, came to RPI on a doctoral residency. He pushed the standard to 5.12. During the late 80's and early 90's much of the rest of the north shore was developed. If you read through the 1990 guidebook you see the names Diane Cornell, Bill Griffith, Lotus Steele, Deb Peranian, David Ackerson, Ming Lin, Steve Brockman, Don Howser, Russ Clune, Roger Piert and Carl (Coach) Maricle. These climbers from the past two paragraphs are responsible for the first ascents of all the north shore routes established before the year 2000.

Sometime in the early 1990's the development activity along the north side died out, and vegetation partially reclaimed the cliff bases. Climbing continued, probably mainly at the Dihedrals and Wind Wall, but there was little organized maintenance.

In the spring of 2003 a local group of climbers again became interested in the north side cliffs. Anchors were placed at the top of the Dihedrals to make it easier to set top ropes and some bolts were placed on the Tier of Fear, Recycle Rock, the Wind Wall and the Dolgeville ROW Wall. Several new climbs were developed, including The Wanderer, Tubby, T2, T5, CSX, Zig Zag, Janis Joplin, Bobby McGee, Juicer and three presently unnamed climbs on the Dolgeville ROW.

Geology

According to a sign on Moss Island, the cliffs there are metasyenite, and I expect all of the cliffs at Little Falls are of the same rock. Syenite is a coarse grained igneous rock that is like granite except it has little or no quartz. Syenite is mostly feldspar, a mineral composed of silicon, oxygen, aluminum and a mixture of potassium and sodium (the orthoclase or alkali feldspars) or silicon, oxygen, aluminum and a mixture of calcium and sodium (the plagioclase feldspars).

There are a lot of igneous rocks with the main constituents being quartz, plagioclase feldspar and alkali feldspar. The triangle drawing below in Figure 8 shows how they are named. Notice that syenite is mostly alkali feldspar.

Syenite is a relatively rare rock, but it also occurs in the Adirondacks. For example, the Pitchcoff cliffs are syenite. Notice across the bottom of the triangle to the right side is a rock composed almost entirely of plagioclase feldspar, named anorthosite. Also relatively rare, anorthosite composes much of the moon, and also the High Peaks area of the Adirondacks!

The Little Falls cliffs are metasyenite; not syenite; the “meta” means the rock has been buried deep underground and subject to high pressures and temperatures that cause structure changes. The rock classification then changes from igneous to metamorphic. Also, the Adirondack rock is metamorphic, so the terms metasyenite and metanorthosite should be used there.

Because of small amounts of iron, metasyenite weathers to a maple syrup brown color. However, you will notice that much of the surface of the dihedral cliffs is black.

According to local lore, this is due to a series of forest fires along the base of the cliff that blackened the face. A local name for the cliffs is “burned rocks.” Whether the fires blackened the face or it is due to another cause (such as bacteria) I do not know. You will notice in places where the black surface has broken off the rock is the normal brown underneath.

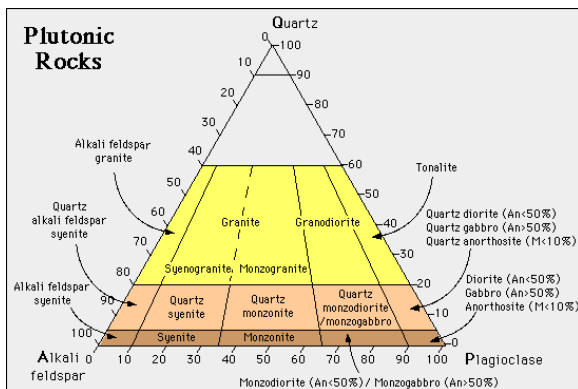


Figure 8. The Rock Triangle

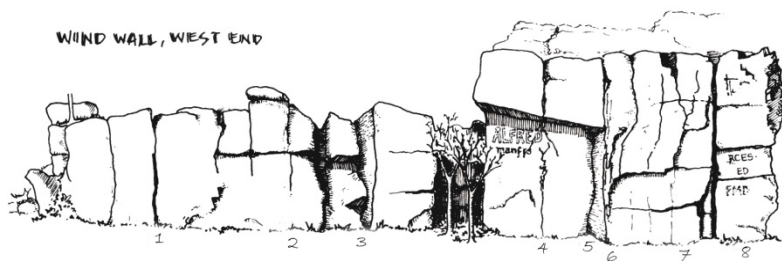
Wind Wall

The Wind Wall is either named for the former mayor of Little Falls, or it is named for the bridge it nearly sits under (which in turn is named for the mayor). Ted Wind was mayor of Little Falls for 33 years, retiring at the end of 2007. This south facing crag sits on the southern edge of Highway 5, a couple hundred feet west of where the Wind bridge tees into the highway. If you walk around to the back of the cliff you will actually walk on the edge of highway 5. The cliff itself and the flat area at the base of the Wind Wall is on the privately owned parcel discussed in the introduction. The flat area above the cliffs is part of the highway right-of-way (ROW).

To get to the cliff, from the north end of the Wind Bridge turn left (west) on Highway 5 and drive a few hundred feet to the stoplight. Turn left on River Road, which curves around left and heads east, right past the Wind Wall. Please do not park at the base of the cliffs; it is best to be inconspicuous. Drive on past and park underneath the bridge a few hundred feet further on. Walk back up the road. Below the west end of the cliff there is a path from the road up to the wall.

To set up top ropes without doing any climbs, go to the west end of the wall and scramble up to the highway. Walk along the shoulder back to the east for about 100 ft and then scramble up to the top of the cliff on some easy step like features. The original guide divided the Wind Wall into west and east sections; even though it is a small cliff I will continue with that format.

West End of the Wind Wall



1. Local Hero 5.10b G

An off-width hand and fist crack leading to a finery finish.

2. T&A 5.11d TR*

Stands for tendonitis and arthritis, both of which your fingers will experience on this short but demanding problem. Climb a perplexing sequence of downpulls and sidecuts on a choppy face to reach an incipient crack that turns into a shallow corner. This will get you to a disappointingly spare horizontal. Traverse left to the next vertically oriented crack and then power-tip to the top. 25 feet of pain. A variation is

3. Faces in the Crowd 5.10 TR

Find the narrow buttress in a shallow alcove with a small, moon-shaped overlap ten feet off the ground in a left-facing corner. This route -- almost a long boulder problem -- climbs the two small roofs.

4. Alfred Overhang 5.11c/d PG***

A classic. The piton below the roof recalls a time when this route was used as an aid climb. A strenuous, constantly demanding adventure. Take the obvious line (often wet) to an awkward stance below the roof. Swing over and make a few more thoughtful moves to the belay ledge above. A pumper!

5. Loose Footed 5.11b R**

Continuous and sometimes a bit wet. Climb the corner to the roof and then turn the roof on the right. Follow a system of easier cracks to the top.

6. Aversion Streak 5.10a R

Instead of in the corner, start out on the arête and climb directly to the crack system part of Loose Footed.

7. Wing Tips 5.10d PG*

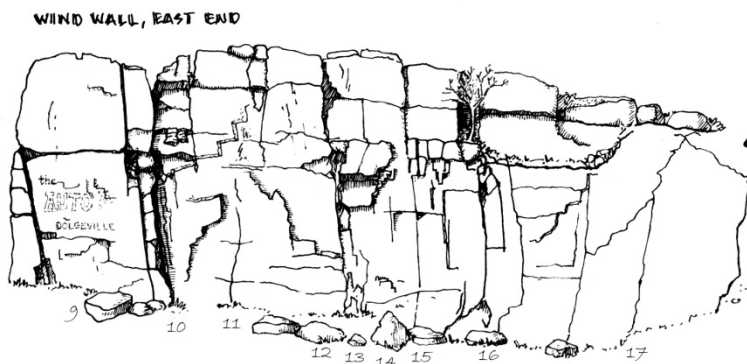
The face right of Aversion Streak has an excellent route on its right side. Mantle horizontal cracks to reach a shallow right-facing corner. Climb up to reach another horizontal (look for the piton), then work slightly left and up to a pair of shallow cracks (sometimes wet) that lead to the top. Easy for the grade once the sequence is discovered.

8. Recess Time 5.9+ R

Climb more or less directly up the center of a narrow buttress split by two obvious horizontal cracks. Short but excellent; thought provoking to lead. A variation is

Var1 Boxer Shorts 5.10b TR Climb along the right edge above the two horizontal cracks.

East End Wind Wall



9. Reserve

10. Wind Crack 5.7 G*

Locate a series of small tight blocks in a vertical crack system. Follow this line straight to the top.

V1 Hard to Hold 5.10a G Harder than it looks. Climb the main block-and-crack system but step left about half way up and reach into the narrow crack above. Awkward jams (that benefit smaller hands) lead to a very difficult mantle at the top.

V2 Pants in a Cloud 5.7 R From the main crack system, move right to a series of shallow 'steps' on the face. diagonalling up and further right to reach a small roof and the top.

V3 Almost Like Magic 5.10c TR Almost its own separate route. Face climb or traverse left on an undercling to reach some shallow right-facing edges on a scooped face. Work your way to ledges and finish on the previous route.

11. Reserve

12. The Wanderer 5.7 Sport

Just left of D'Vine Crack bolts meander up to left and then more straight up to clip-in anchors at top. Route intended as a warm-up, easy way to get to top of cliff, and fun for less experienced climbers. Originally this climb had no name, but this one appears to have become attached to it.

13. D'Vine Crack 5.7 G*

Named for its ability to sprout poison ivy. Follow the slightly leaning crack system to the top. Good jamming technique is required.

14. Squeeze Play 5.10c R**

Just right of D'Vine Crack is a narrow face with a distinct pair of squarish red slabs set out from the wall.-one above the other. They mark the line of this demanding route. Stay between the two routes on either side, working your way past the red slabs, a pair of good horizontal cracks and some thin face climbing to reach a final vertical seam. Carry a couple very small cams and a couple large ones; double ropes help.

15. Digits or Aunt Smears 5.10d/5.11a PG**

Another classic & terrific climbing in a small package. Locate the thin, perfect crack above a flat boulder. Climb to the "triangle," then work right and up to a hand slot, then back left to the final finger cracks. Enjoyable and generally well-protected with the hardest moves near the ground. The difficulty of the initial crack is relative to finger size.

16. Fast on the Trigger 5.10b PG*

Work up a thin finger crack to painful jams. A few feet higher and you can reach a ledge. Take the shallow chimney to finish.

17. The Mind Thing 5 9- PG

A long boulder problem. Climb the crack system 20' right of Fast on the Trigger. Ledges to either side offer an easy out.

18 – 37. Reserve

Cesspool Pond

I don't think it is really a cesspool; rainwater just runs in from the west end of the cliff and sits here. Still, it is not very pretty. The pond drains through a pipe under the railroad, but the pipe is set too high so there is always water in the pond. All the cesspool pond cliff and the pond itself are on the large private parcel.

The easiest way get to the top of the cesspool cliff is to park up above it (north of it) in the small pullout on the side of highway 5. This pullout will hold maybe 5 vehicles. Walk back west 200 ft along the highway where there is a trail going south. This trail wanders first right then left and drops onto the old railroad ROW. At this point, if you turn back left (east) Recycle Rock is about 200 ft away (immediately below the cars). For now though, turn right and walk along the ROW a few hundred feet. Just before you come to the place where there are small cliffs on both sides of the ROW (there are climbs here too), turn left and you can walk to the top of the Texas Peninsula. There is nothing harder than some 4th class scrambling. There are some nice trees near the edge to rappel from. For the other cesspool cliffs you just have to go back east.

Texas Peninsula

38. Angle Dust 5.8 G

A short, off-width crack that lends itself to good technique (many climbs do). It is ten feet left of the giant boulder on the escape ledge.

39. Mr. Clark meets the Burrito Master 5.10c TR*

A Randall-Skibinski original. Short but very sweet. Climb the scoops, seams and small roofs on the rounded corner/face just right of Angle Dust.

40. Earth to Doris 5.10b G**

On the left side of the "Washbasin" a pair of parallel cracks lead to a tree stump. Climb the left crack to the slot, than swing over the blocks above to reach the top.

41. Crucial Groove 5.9+ G**

Deceptive and fine. Climb the wonderful off-hand crack (5 8) on the right side of the Washbasin, taking one step left at the 'T' and working your way up the diagonalling crack above.



42. Good Friday 5.8+ PG**

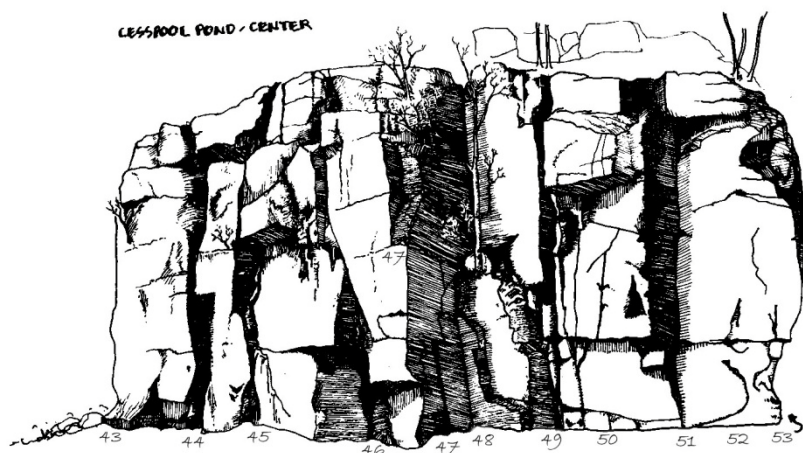
Easier for tall people. Climb the hand crack (5.8)-and step right at the 'T'. making a long mantle on the edge to reach better holds. Owing to the traverse; there is some potential for a pendulum fall on this route. A variation is

Var1 Mud-Sucking Tootsie Roll Eater 5.11b TR Climb up between the crack and the rounded edge (Mona Lisa Love Muscle), then step left and climb up the right side of the steep face directly above the 'T'. Highly contrived but thoroughly enjoyable.

43. Mona Lisa Love Muscle 5.10d TR*

Several hard mantles on the rounded edge will connect you with either of the two routes above.

Center Cliffs



44. Unnamed 5.5 TR

The steep-sided open book. Somewhat ruined by a huge dead tree low on the route and a boulder pile at the top.

45. Chin Music 5.8 G**

Well worth the trouble of leading. Locate the climb from above by hunting for a 2" crack in the middle of a blueberry patch on a flat ledge just east of the boulder pile. A hanging belay at the bottom can be easily established from a birch growing out of a crack 8' above water level. After a few moves around some blocks the route follows a perfect hand crack through two small overhangs and a corner.

46. Unnamed (No information)

Fight your way over a roof in a small corner ten feet above the water. Work up and left past a bulge in a triangular corner to a small ledge in another shallow corner. Thin cracks lead straight up to slots and the top. Continuous and hard.

47. Rutting Hog Dance 5.11a TR*

Rap down Indiana Nose Pick to water level. Climb a short hand crack in the left wall, then step out and around the corner at a horizontal crack to confront a short, black face cut by horizontal seams. Stay somewhat right, making difficult moves into a shallow right-facing groove with a mantle to the top. The best belay is from a group of small birches.

48. Indiana Nose Pick 5.7 G*

The large left-facing corner with a tree on the half-way ledge. Begin at water level. Surprisingly awkward near the top.

49. Lady J 5.8 G*

This off-width chimney is short but confining. A couple large Friends will protect it but it's easier just to top-rope. The route is best located from above by peeping down behind two small birches at the edge of the Carpophobe terrace.

50. Carpophobe 5.10b/5.11b TR**

An excellent route, the difficulty of which depends upon the exit you take. Rap down to the pile of blocks at the bottom of Lady J. Traverse right to reach a diagonalling finger-crack cutting a 2' roof. A couple hard moves on the crack and a delicate mantle puts you beneath the big roof. Variations are

Var1 Poof Roof 5 11b** Climb left-center over the big roof.

Var2 Chinese Logic 5.10d* Right of the roof is a bucket. Mantle on it to the top.

Var3 Gasp Clasp 5 10b* From the bucket stretch right to the arête. A daring clasp or two will get you up.

51. James Brown's Paradox Philosophy 5.7 G**

Rap to water level and climb a superb lay-back crack in the right-facing corner. A variation is

Var1 Goof Proof Roof 5.10c TR Instead of stepping out left at the top, step right and try the roof.

52. Geomancer 5.11+ TR

Exhausting and thin. Rap to water level and climb the center of the orange gently overhanging face to the right of James Brown's Paradox Philosophy. After the bulge finish by swinging Goof Proof Roof.

53. Celibate Catfish 5.7+ G

The right-facing corner grove at the end of the Carpophobe terrace. Sometimes a bit dirty.

54. My Daddys at the Pit 5.11b/c R**

Ming Lin found a test-piece for tall people on this squatty, pinched and overhanging route. Two rusted pegs mark the belay point just above water level. After the first bolt traverse and climb the left side of the buttress. A variation is

Var1 5.11 d PG Take a crooked line just right of the arête powering past two bolts to an exhausting finish.

Florida Peninsula



55. Project X 5.8+ PG

Start in an open book at water level left of the peninsula. Stem the corner to a blocky ceiling which is turned on the right by means of a slot. Move up and then left through another slot to reach the tree ledge above.

56. First Blood 5.9+ PG**

Put up on the lead in February, this fine route has a variety of face and crack techniques. Climb an obvious open book with a slot, laybacking onto a narrow ledge. Shuffle left a couple steps then face climb straight up to a slanting terrace beneath a large roof. Step back right and work up a short crack above.

57. Stump the Droids 5.11a PG**

Use the same start as First Blood, but continue up the initial corner to a terrace on the right. Work your way into the V-slot on the left side of the big roof, then up to the "Mental Block." A couple moves on the arête will get you out the top.

58. Fair Weather Friend 5.9-5.10b TR

Saved from greatness by access to too many good holds on the right. Oh well. Start in the left of two chimneys and escape onto the face (left) when flakes lead you that way. Avoid buckets on the right and make some hard reaches to gain the small platform just right of a big roof. End by either climbing straight up or by stepping way left to an exposed mantle.

59. Easy Out 5.1 G

The squeeze chimney to the right of Fair Weather Friend.

60. Bromadosous 5.10a G*

Contrary to its name, you will need good feet to make this climb work. Climb the face and cracks just right of Easy Out, making a weird move into the "Butt" and then jamming the finger crack above to finish.

61. Butt Woman from Hell 5.10c TR**

Savage and strange. Start on the face just right of an outside left-facing corner (see sketch) above a flat terrace. Make a few bouldering-type moves to reach a horizontal crack and better holds. Follow intersecting cracks to a wide roof which is passed on the right. Establish yourself in the "butt" (that's right) by means of peculiar technique, then reach for thin folds to surmount the second roof. A mantle to bushes completes this short but memorable route.

62. (No information)

The crack/off-width on the left side of the broken face to the right of the Butt Woman from Hell terrace.

63. (no information)

The face.

64. (no information)

The crack on the right side.

65 – 70 Reserved

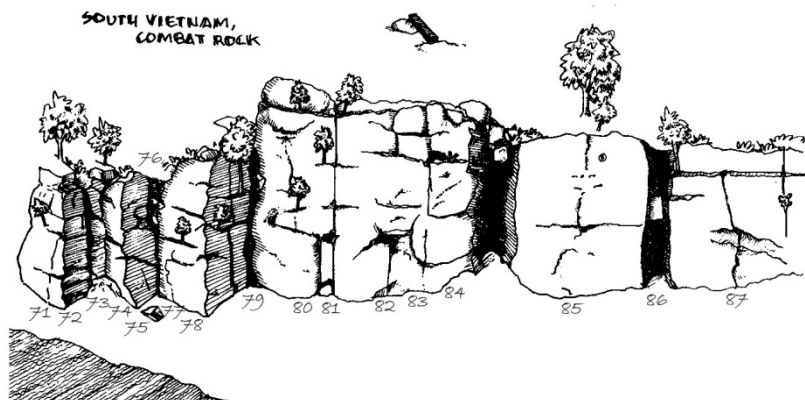


The Cesspool Pond Cliffs

Combat Rock

The Combat Rock cliffs are on the large private parcel of land.

South Vietnam



71. Skin So Soft 5.9 R

Find a 30' gray face just a few feet from the water's edge at the left end of the good rock. Climb the face just left of the edge. Don't blow the tricky protection placement at the crux.

72. Funeral in Iran 5.10a R*

Locate a steep right-facing 30' slab with a small roof 10' off the ground and a horizontal crack a few feet above that. Climb up the right side of the face. mantling with care over the roof. Better pro takes you back left. Move to the middle and up at the top.

73. Andrect 5.3 G

The big crack in the dirty open book.

74. Slipped Disc 5.7 R

Almost a boulder problem. Use the face left of a sharp arête with one hand on the edge.

75. Cranial Mush 5.10b R

Another longish boulder problem: don't screw-up the first moves because there is no pro until the horizontal crack 12' off the ground. Use the edge on your left and face holds on the right to get there, then go for easier ground.

76. An Open and Closed Book 5.5 PG

The open book with a medley of dirty, awkward cracks. Better than it looks, actually.

77. Puzzled By Nature 5.10b R*

A short series of devious moves gets you to the small left-facing corner just right of the Book. Mantle, then move up and slightly right climbing to a thin crack and the summit block. Seriously run-out at the start.

78. Cardiac Arête 5.11a PG*

Climb the arête and the face to its left. The bolt protects the lower moves but things can get a little hairy just as the difficulties do ease off somewhat. Variations are

V1 Blur Hindu 5.7 PG Climb the reverse side of the arête, relying somewhat on the face to the right. Better protection than it looks and better climbing

V2 The Poodle Bites 5.8 PG* Take the obvious hand crack and continue straight up

79. Cotton Tail 5.3 G

The big crack in the back of the corner. Watch out for loose rocks!

80. Brain Maggot Margin 5.10d/5.11d TR

A shallow left-facing corner (bear left of the start for Hippity-Hop) leads to a couple of tricky moves: left across the orange face on edges and a horizontal seam. Make a difficult mantle, then a few easier moves lead to odd combinations and some loose surface rock which places you below a bulging roof. Reach for a good ledge that presents you with the very awkward "Mickey Mantle." Not using the tree increases the standard a full grade.

81. Hippity Hop 5.7+ G*

A couple of tricky moves off the ground will get you to a stump and the start of a beautiful hand crack. That's the hard part. The upper section is a cruise.

82. Big-Headed Boy 5.9- R

The crux is difficult to protect until you are past it! Follow an obvious vertical crack/seam to a block and a small roof. A shallow horizontal crack and better holds above lead to an unnerving mantle. Move up and left to the crack on the left side of the block above.

83. Protein Turbo-Charge 5.9 R

Just right of Big-Headed Boy a shallow left-leaning groove leads to a move right around a bulge, then a mantle, a vertical crack and small ledges in a straight line to the top.

84. Spanking Daddy (Instead) 5.10? PG

Why not? Start by bouldering a move (V1) off the ground just right of Protein Turbo-Charge: use the horizontal crack left of a small tree. It gets much easier above.

85. Industrial Zouk 5.10c PG*

A good route, a little slim at the start but well-protected (bolt) at the crux. Climb the center of the somewhat concave 30' slab located between two chimneys. The start is a little touchy: good holds in an awkward combination

will bring you to a horizontal crack. A vertical finger slot takes a #2 TCU and a couple easier moves will let you clip the bolt.

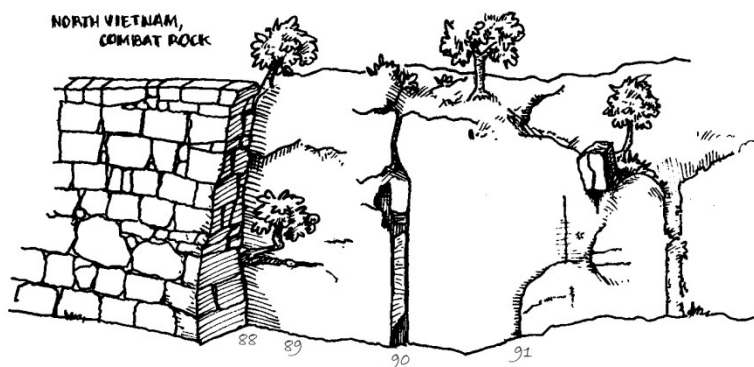
86. Chieu Hoi 5.2 PG

Climb the chimney on the right.

87. Bunny Trail 5.7 G

Another long boulder problem which requires same honest jamming. An obvious, slightly diagonalling finger crack at the right end of the crag.

North Vietnam



88. Joes Corner 5.5 G

Something different: a route that climbs a corner formed on the right by rock and on the left by quarry blocks.

89. Paternity Nerves 5.11a PG/R*

A few feet right of Joes Corner flakes lead to a thin horizontal. Then follow a thin vertical crack. Once you've bypassed the wide horizontal slot about mid-height the crux is the unprotected slab above. Nervous fathers can step right to avoid that bit. The nervous father was Bill Griffith; his son Keegan can be seen in the Recycle Rock photo.

90. Ma Bell Calling 5.9 G

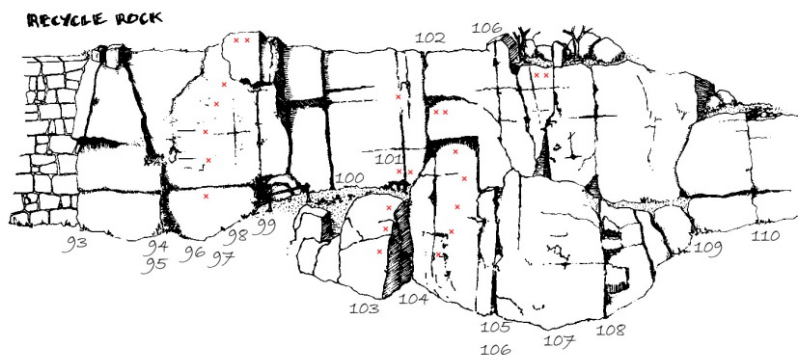
Ascend the obvious parallel finger-cracks to a slot. Scramble to the top.

91. Arthur Murray Two-Step 5.8 PG

A good start in search of a stronger finish. Locate a left-facing bulge behind a big dead tree 10' right of Ma Bell. Work up to a fun move over the block above. Diagonal left to finish.

92 Reserved

Recycle Rock



Recycle Rock is another of the cliffs on the large private land parcel. It is hidden in the woods and not visible from the railroad tracks in the summer. Also, it is shaded and cooler in hot weather than the dihedrals or the wind wall. You can walk along the tracks to the cliff from either direction. From the east walk about 225 yards past the old stone factory to where there is a chest high rock shelf and then walk into the woods. From the west start from underneath the Wind bridge and walk the tracks going about 135 yards past the edge of the cesspool pond to the rock shelf. However, the easiest way to get to this cliff is to park in the small pullout up on Highway 5. When you get out of your car you are right above the top of Recycle Rock. However, it is not convenient to get down from here, so walk back west about 200 ft to where a path goes south. This path drops down onto the old Dolgeville railroad right-of-way. Walk back east on the right-of-way to the top of the cliff and either rappel down from one of the anchors or scramble down around the east side of the cliff. There are some superb climbs here with possibilities for sport, trad or top roping.

93. Jungle Gym 5.10a G*

At the far left end of the crag where it abuts the retaining wall a perfect crack splits a three foot ceiling 25' off the ground. Either climb the corner formed by the rock and retaining wall to a step out under the roof or climb directly (5.10c TR) up the rock via two horizontal cracks and a few face holds. The crack leads directly to the top.

94. The Slant 5.10a PG

Right of the previous route a wide crack leads to a ledge with the stump of a bush on it. It continues by diagonalling left across the slab above. Harder and better than it looks.

95. Tubby 5.9 PG**

Start on The Slant to get up to the ledge. Then move to the right 3 or 4 feet using the small horizontal cracks for your hands and feet. Using whatever footholds you can find, stand up and make a long reach to the good hold

above (crux). If you can't make this move it is possible to continue up The Slant a little further and then step across back onto the route. Continue angling slightly right and then at the top swing right and up to the clip in anchors.

96. Fear and Loathing 5.11b Sport*

Five bolts to a clip in anchor. The first of three finger killers put up here by Randall and Skibinski. Start in a rounded concavity and mantle to a good crack five feet right of The Slant. An odd combination of layback and face climbing moves around an edged depression will bring you to better holds and the lower angled slab above. Trend right to gain an edge and then the top.

97. Denizens of Delirium 5.11c TR*

Five feet right of Fear and Loathing climb somewhat more obvious edges into ever more dubious surroundings. Use whatever you can find to surmount the black face above.

98. Doesn't Matter 5.11a TR*

Oh, but it does. A good route thought almost a variation of the previous line. Start off on good edges just to the right of Denizens of Delirium, then fight your way through a blank section at mid-height to reach some vertical seams above.

99. Blockhead Navigator 5.11a G**

A fine crack exercise, somewhat easy for the grade. Climb out of the niche directly above the birch trees that hold the railing. Make an awkward reach to a finger crack. Tip-locks lead straight up to where a few dirty moves around a giant block will get you to the top.

100. Unnamed (No information)

The vegetated off-width crack that ascends the left side of the gray face.

101. Childs Play 5.10a PG**

The distinct crack splitting the middle right side of the gray face. This climb can be started at the top of Stretch Marks or from the ground where Stokers Fix begins. One bolt has been placed up high where the protection was thin so the protection rating may now be G. On top of the cliff hangers have been placed so this climb can be top roped. The hangers are set so 48 inch slings will just reach over the edge of the cliff.

102. Mung Corner 5.9 PG

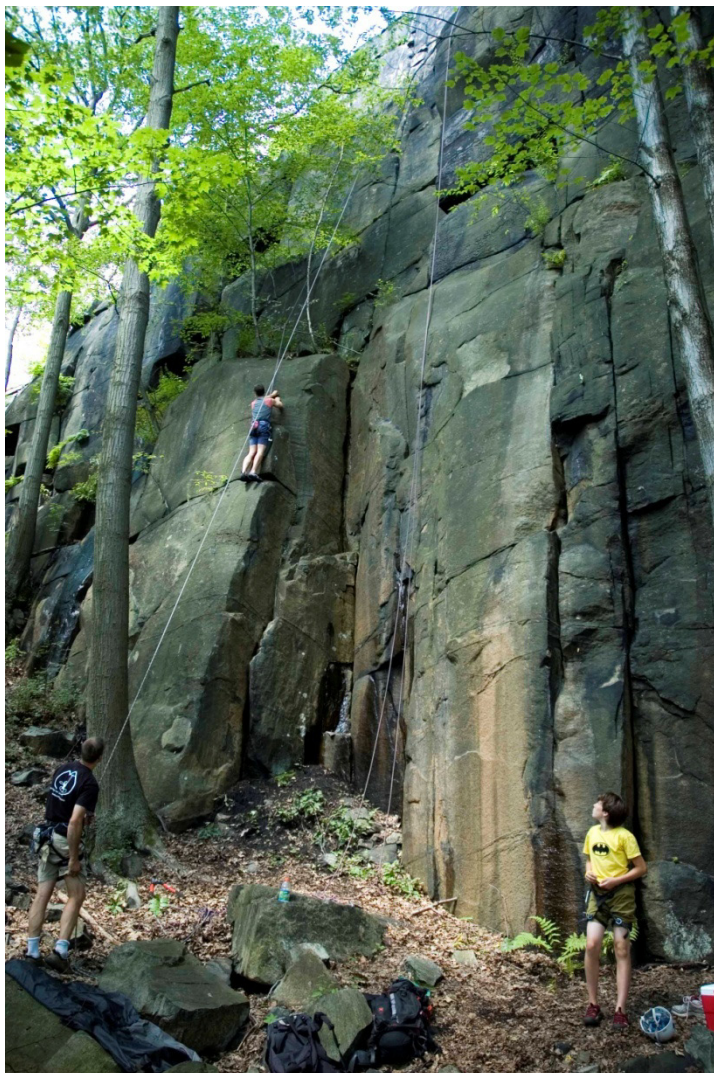
The left-facing corner at the right end of the gray face has a hand-sized and very awkward crack in it.

103. Stretch Marks 5.11a Sport**

Three bolts to anchors. Climb the right side of the face, reaching around the right side of the arête for holds as needed. Gets harder as you go up. A delightful exercise in footwork.

104. Stokers Fix 5.11a Bolted**

Five bolts to anchors. Start in the corner and move up and right to the first bolt. Continue up and then slightly back left and over the roof to the anchors. On top of the cliff there are hangers so this climb can be top roped. The hangers are set so 48 inch slings will just reach over the edge of the cliff. If you top rope the climb, the section above the regular anchors to the top of the cliff is 5.12.



Working on Stretch Marks to see where the bolts should go. The Sure Thing is just left of Keegan Griffith (yellow T-shirt).

105. The Sure Thing 5.8 G*

The historical rating of this climb is 5.8 although the start might be 5.9. Where a pair of cracks form a flat pillar climb up and left (10') to reach a

comfortable pedestal. Easy climbing takes you to the mid-height ledge. Angle to the right and head toward the anchors via one of the cracks.

106. Psycho Cha-Cha 5.10d G*

Contrived but very worthwhile. Start as if for The Sure Thing, but stay with the right hand crack. Finger jam through a steep section to reach the sloping half-way ledge. Bear slightly left from there to a distinct diagonal finger crack. Pass horizontal edges to reach a distinct indentation where the crack thins to a seam. A short set of tricky face moves at this point will take you directly to the top. Copping out on the easier holds to the right will lower both the grade and your self-esteem.

107. Dreamland 5.11b R **

This is the apparently blank face between Psycho Cha-Cha and Legitimate Beef. Yep, sorry to say, Berzins led this one without top-roping or placing a bolt. Brave boys and girls will begin by bouldering a few moves to reach a small ledge. Thin things will get you over the bulge and in worse trouble. Now reach left to place a blind-but-solid nut. Next, take a deep breath and puzzle out the frictiony moves (right or left) that will bring you to the large sloping ledge. Continue straight up to the anchor shared with The Sure Thing and Legitimate Beef.

108. Legitimate Beef 5.9- PG*

The first vertical crack right of the Dreamland face. Better than it looks. Climb straight up to a tricky block, then on to the right side of the sloping ledge. Finish on any of the cracks that head to the shared anchor

109. A Layback 5.6 TR

The very short layback crack behind a huge tree on the terrace above and right of Legitimate Beef.

110. Darkest Argentina 5.7 G

Look **for** a thin finger crack splitting the short black slab uphill and 30' right of Legitimate Beef.

111 – 130. Reserved

Eastward from Recycle Rock a series of broken cliffs extends

Wasted Youth Wall

The Wasted Youth Wall is the first crag east of the old gravel factory. It is apparently a pretty blank face that is largely unexplored. I know little about it at this time.

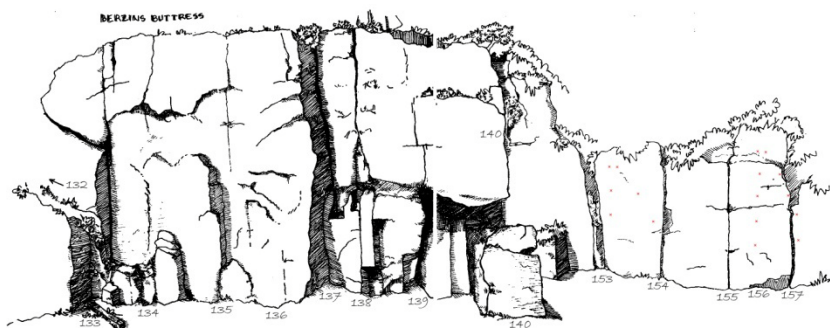
131. Lost Children 5.8 R

This route boulders left off the terrace (near the giant oak tree) of Wasted Youth Wall, avoiding the main face and reaching a small platform 12' up. Ascend dirty corners to good cracks and the top. The protection at the bottom is iffy, but then who would want to do a second ascent anyway?

132. Unnamed (No information)

Scramble up the grass and dirt ramp left of Doktor Ratt. Directly behind a maple tree a left-facing corner forms an arch topped by a roof. Climb the corner (same loose rock). then traverse left to a thin vertical crack. Power through the roof and reach right for a block. Easier climbing in the smaller left-facing corner system above brings you to the top.

Berzins Buttress



The next cliff east is Berzins Buttress. The ownership of the Wasted Youth Wall, Berzins Buttress and the series of cliffs to the east (Amtrak Arete, Smith Rock, Tier of Fear and the Dihedrals) is not completely, although they are probably on the private parcel. The most accessible source of information is the Herkimer County GIS map. If you wish to see the map, go to <http://herkimercounty.sdgny.com/search.aspx>. The ID for the private parcel of land is 115.70-1-1 which you can enter into the search box. You can look at either the tax map or the GIS map; the latter is the most appropriate because it shows both the property boundaries and the aerial photography.

If you play around for a while you can see that at the western end, the old gravel factory is on the private parcel; the boundary between the private land and the CSX ROW appears to be 15 – 20 ft feet south (closer to the tracks) of the edge of the factory. As you go east from the factory the boundary runs more or less parallel to the tracks. You can't really pinpoint the face of the cliffs in the aerial photography, but the property line appears to be close to the face. If you go very far away from the face of the cliff you will be on the

CSX ROW; if you climb a route and walk north a ways you will be on the private parcel.

While it seems likely that routes such as Doktor Ratt and Haggis have been climbed before, it is ever more certain that no one has ever looked at the rock between these two lines in quite the same way as Martin Berzins. The superb rock, sustained difficulties and challenging protection of all three played perfectly to Berzins' strengths. Always strident, almost Pentecostal in his zeal for "a job done right," Berzins opened not only three excellent routes on this 50' face but also more than a few minds.

133. Doktor Ratt 5-9*

Jam and layback a strange crack in the obvious right-facing orange colored corner above some large blocks. When the main groove turns left, continue straight up by connecting finger cracks and mantling into bushes. A worthwhile route.

134. Easy Goer 5 12d***

The hardest of Berzins' three superb routes on this face. Easy Goer was unseconded at the time and has not as yet seen a subsequent ascent. Locate a choppy, all too obvious finger crack in the orange wall just right of Doktor Ratt. Reach into the crack and struggle upward until a reach right for a tweeker will allow a desperate snatch to a slightly better hold. From the ramp continue with interest to gain the easier crack above.

135. America Without Tears 5.11c PG**

Intriguing climbing. Odd moves on the right side of an obvious black pillar lead to a swing and mantle and an excellent stance from which to contemplate the sobering moves above. Place your protection in a thin crack to the right but then move left and climb a small corner to a horizontal seam which is traversed back right. One more hard move here will bring you to a dilemma: the placement of a solid nut where you've just placed your hand! A perfect finger-pocket leads to easier moves above.

136. Sunday Silence 5.12a PG**

Who but Berzins would have found a route here? Begin in the shallow open book just a few left of the Haggis corner and just right of America Without Tears. Protect in the cracks to your left and right before you mantle onto an awkward block beneath a bulge. Another tricky move leads to a relatively good stance to place a small wire (shaky) in a shallow diagonal crack. This piece protects the very thin crux move above. Stay with the obvious crack to better pro and the top.

137. Haggis 5.5 PG

Less pleasant. Climb straight up the obvious right-facing corner that divides the main face in half.

138. Billy Tipton 5.8+**

Looks can be deceiving. Different than it appears and a much better route than it looks to be from the ground. Climb the face and crack just right of Haggis to a slot and sloping ledge, then directly up the excellent crack above.

(Billy Tipton was a family man and a jazz musician. When he died in 1988 his autopsy revealed that he was actually a woman). Variations are

V1. Autopsy Surprise 5.10a* Take on the finger crack at the bottom directly.

V2. Tenor's Gasp 5.10b* Struggle into the right-facing corner and follow it over a small triangular roof to reach the sloping ledge.

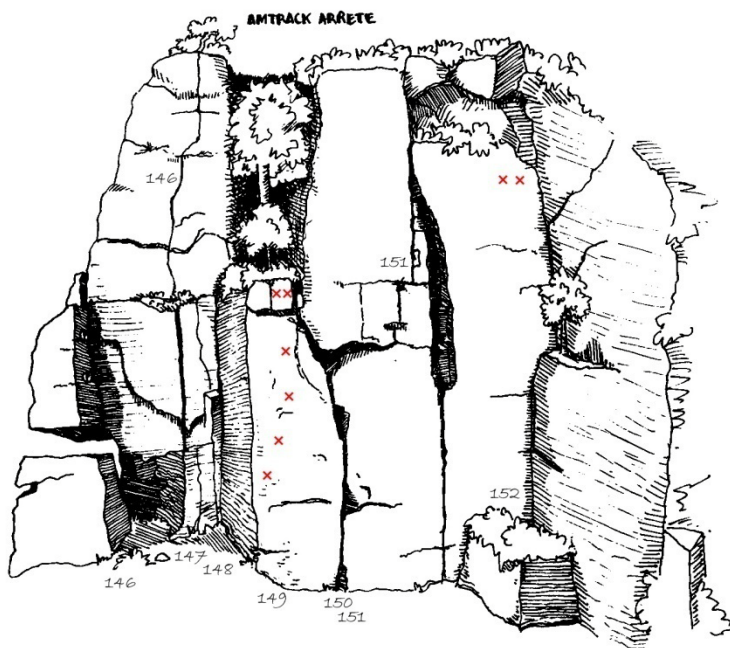
139. Motor Box 5.9+ R

Not quite great. Climb a short right-facing corner under the big roof. Step out and make a tricky move over the roof (5.8. poor pro) to establish yourself on the sloping ledge above. Follow a thin crack until you can step right to a bushy ledge. Two moves short of greatness.

140. Noq Tube Heat 5.11? TR

Start by bouldering the front of the large block below the big roof. Step up to the black arête above. Same thin moves on the left side of the arête will get you to easier ground.

Amtrak Arête



141 – 145. Reserved

146. Skin Wax Crack 5.10b/c PG*

Here at last is that rare climb where the crux is actually easier for small people! Climb blocks to the obvious off-hand crack in a pod-like left handed corner. Once you have struggled to the halfway ledge, step right to a thin crack in the narrow buttress above. Climb up (5.8+ R) using a variety of techniques. Protection in the upper part can be awkward to arrange.

147. Substitute Teaching 5.10b/c G

The daunting off-finger crack just right of Skin Wax Crack is, unfortunately, ruined by easy access to simple footing on the right. For those with a strong sense of moral purpose, the crack is a worthwhile exercise and definitely easier for big people! The cruddy mantle onto the mid-way ledge is actually harder than the crack -- no matter where you put your foot. Finish on Skin Wax Crack or rap off the tree.

148. Crud Corner 5.6 PG

Not that bad, really. but very short.

149. Face Off In Albania 5.11 Sport

Four bolts to anchors. Climb the narrow face using the arête and some thin ledges on the face. The Buzz Junky crack is off limits.

150. Buzz Junky 5.7 G**

A good crack exercise for the beginning leader. Climb the obvious finger/hand crack, veering left at the Y-junction. Continue up to the shared anchor with Face Off in Albania



Randy Big Dog on Buzz Junky; Gray Watkins belays. Bolt line for Face Off in Albania on the left

151. The Reagan Years 5.10a PG**

It keeps moving senselessly to the right! Climb the first 20' of Buzz Junky. but traverse right at the horizontal hand crack. Snake up a thin crack, then step right, up again and veer right into the main crack system. Climb an

awkward corner to rappel anchors shared with Harder than Your Husband. Protection can be a bit hard to arrange in the middle. A variation is

V1. Citizen Cohn 5.11b PG Another Berzins lead. Take the direct start to the main crack. Thin fingers, laybacking and stemming will help.

152. Harder Than Your Husband 5.9 G**

A nice climb up a naughty corner. The first thirty feet of this perfect corner have been climbed by laybacking, jamming, stemming, "unching" and every other known technique. Step left at the top to the rappel anchors shared with The Reagan Years.

153. T2 5.7 Sport

Two bolts to anchors. Good practice for beginners.

154. T5 5.7 Sport

Two bolts to anchors. More good practice for beginners. Start at the crack about eight feet right of T2. Angle left as you climb and end up at the T2 anchor.

155. Trojan Elite 5.7 G**

Solid protection. Very short but very nice. Find the perfect finger crack in a beautiful face fifty feet right of the Harder than Your Husband corner. Should be able to use the Thanador anchor to lower off.

156. Thanador 5.9 Sport**

Four bolts to anchor. A surprisingly fine climb on the brown face just right of Trojan Elite. Climb the center of the brown face 5' right of Trojan Elite on obvious holds. A difficult move will get you to a good horizontal crack. Climb up and right, making a high step onto a shallow, diagonalling ledge which brings you to the top. Stay away from the Trojan Elite crack.

157. CSX 5.7 Sport

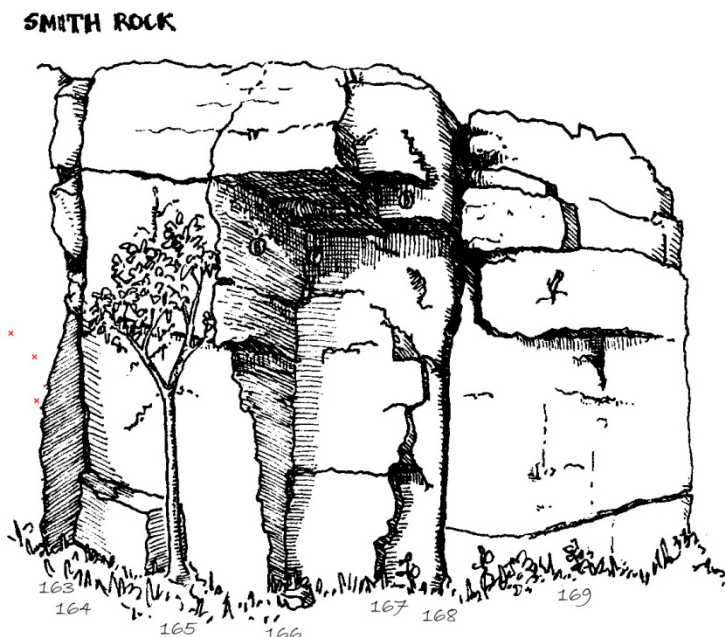
Four bolts to anchor. Start a few feet right of Thanador and follow the bolt line, moving left at the top to the shared anchor.

158 – 162 Reserved



More Randy & Gray on CSX, Thanador bolt line to the left and Trojan Elite crack left of that.

Smith Rock



Locate the crag by walking 100 past the west end of the Dihedrals: the rock is 35 high. black, with a distinctively tiered ceiling in the center.

163. Zig Zag 5.8 Sport

At the left edge of Smith Rock there is a bolt line that goes up, then left, then up again to an anchor. Some delicate moves on the traverse

164. Unnamed 5.9 TR

A short inside corner leads to a slot in a chimney. Above, separate finger cracks ascend opposite sides of two large chockstones.

165 . Unnamed 5.11c TR

From an obvious block a few feet right of the corner a series of small widely-spaced edges lead to good holds in a horizontal crack. A thin vertical seam reaches the next horizontal. Somewhat easier moves go straight up to the finish.

166. Shock the Monkey 5.11d G***

The most acrobatic sequence of moves in Little Falls. Climb the corner and by-pass the huge roof on the left. An instant classic put up in semi-traditional style by Ming Lin.

167. Power Outage 5.10d G**

Genetics are more important than style in reaching over the double roof of this fine route. Climb a series of small corners to a thin crack splitting the roof. A bolt above (placed on the lead) protects the crux.

168. Prepare to Meet Thy God 5.7 PG

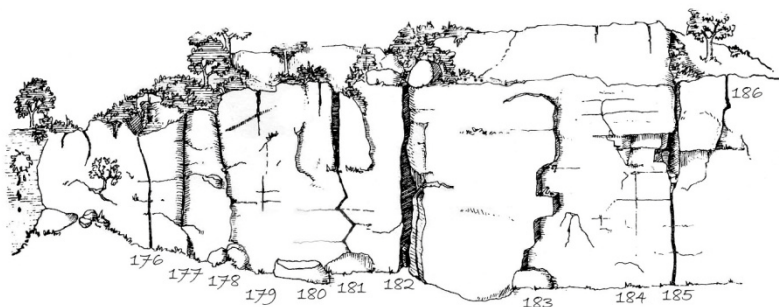
This is the obvious finger/hand crack. Harder than it looks but often soloed.

169. Unnamed 5.7 TR

Boulder a few moves near the center of the blackish face just right of Power Outage. Once you have established your feet at the horizontal crack climb past a triangle and more or less directly over the ceiling above to finish.

170 – 174 Reserved

Tier of Fear



Walk west 100' past the Dihedrals and look for an obvious tree terrace about mid-way up the cliff and left of some broken buttresses and chimneys. Bushwhack to a right-facing corner at the east end of the terrace and climb up the corner onto the tier. Two webbing handholds have been placed to make the climb a little safer.

175. Racing Dog 5.10a Sport**

This climb is actually below the tier. Three bolts to anchors. Locate a clean beige-colored slab directly below the Tier of Fear, starting up a short, right-facing corner. The opening mantle is harder if you are short. Right-trending ledges will lead you to the buttress which is turned at the top. An easier finish (5.7) goes left to a thin crack, or climb the buttress (5.11 +) without turning the corner.

176. Ms. Adventure 510b G*

A short, but excellent climb which was put up on the lead. Very awkward to top-rope because of the bushes at the tope. Climb the slightly diagonal very thin crack to a challenging mantle at the lip of a bulge.

177. Beginner's Luck 5.3 G

The left of a pair of slanting, stepped cracks. The easiest way off but too bushy for easy top-roping.

178. Easy Affair 5.3 G

The right: of the two rounded corners.

179. Small Happy 5.8 G*

Another short beauty. Climb straight up a series of Intersecting cracks. then pass a gap in holds by staying slightly right. A good jam crack above leads directly to a bushy and often muddy mantle. A variation is

V1. By-Pass 5.7 G Work your way up on Easy Affair to a diagonalling dike. Traverse right to the jam crack and up to finish.

180. Thought Police 5.9 R*

You're going to have to relax your mind on this one or you'll be blowing dirt out of your ears. Climbs the face to the right of Small Happy by using two horizontal cracks. a layback (the only pro) and a gripping stretch right.

181. Zig-Zag Crack 5.5 PG

Follow the Z-shaped crack to a squeeze chimney.

182. Fuzzy Tights 5.6 PG

Lose 25 lbs. and try this one again. Go directly up the chimney in the center of the terrace. Since getting stuck is probably more of a problem than falling out "full figure" climbers are advised to move out to the front of the Chimney at the midway point and face climb to the top. A variation is

V1. Girl on a String 5.10b G* Almost a bouldering problem. Jam the off-finger, slightly overhanging crack just 5 ft right of Fuzzy Tights to a good terrace. Step outside and left to the black arête where a couple of moves will bring you to the top.

183. Head Cement 5.7 G

The very obvious right-facing flake and corner system at the center of the terrace. Start at the bottom of the corner making a surprisingly awkward move out under a roof to reach a small ledge with a tree stump. Choose the right technique and pump the crack above until an easy mantle puts you over the top. A variation is

V1. Glue Font Spin 5.8 G* Two steps right of the corner a thin crack leads to a small ledge. Make a couple tricky moves off the ground to a funny mantle on a triangular hold. Step left to the tree stump ledge.

184. Trick Bag 5.11b/5.12b Sport**

** bolts to an anchor. This route is the subject of frequent sieges and few successes. The "height-impaired" will find its difficulties a full grade harder than those over 5'11". Quite sustained for such a short route. Start by following a razor thin crack past a bolt and a peg to reach a good horizontal edge. Step left to a second bolt. then power up the bulging wall above. passing another fixed peg and making a dynamic move for the top. Excellent.

185. The Arrow 5.8 G*

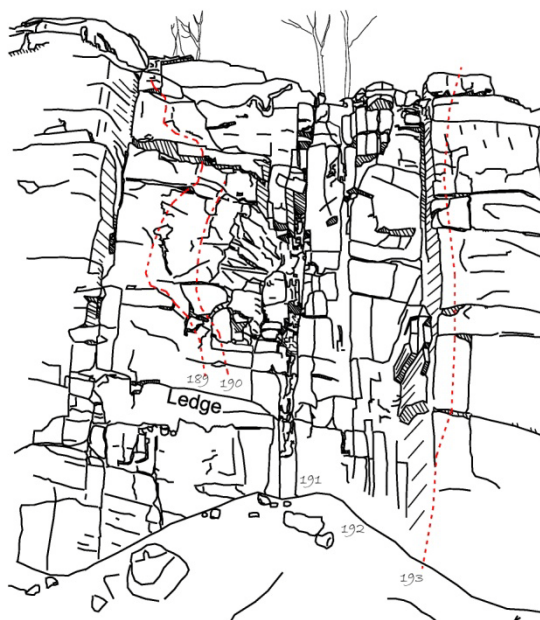
A superb off-hand crack. Climb straight up to a squeeze chimney and the top. Easier or harder depending upon the size of your hand.

186. Risqué Shift 5.9+ G**

A short classic. Climb The Arrow until you can step right under a black roof to a small ledge. A thin vertical crack in a shallow. left-facing corner, leads to better holds. Jams and other maneuvers will take you to the anchor at the top.

187 -188. Reserved

Dihedrals Left Side



189. Janis Joplin 5.10 Sport**

5 bolts to the clip in anchors at the top. The climb begins on a ledge about 12 ft off the ground that you scramble up to. There is a bolt at the ledge to protect the belayer. Perform balancy face moves at the bottom, then go through the overhang (actually one of the easiest parts of the climb). Move to the left and try to get up the rounded off ledge to the clip-on anchors.

190. Bobby McGee 5.9 Sport*

3 bolts to clip in anchors. This route begins at same spot as Janis Joplin, but angles to the right. More nice face moves. To do this route in the prescribed manner you must honor a couple of restrictions. A few feet up the route there is a large block on the ledge to the left; do not put your foot on it. Also, stay on the face, do not slide right to go up the arête. There is a hard to see hold on the face – I hope you find it.

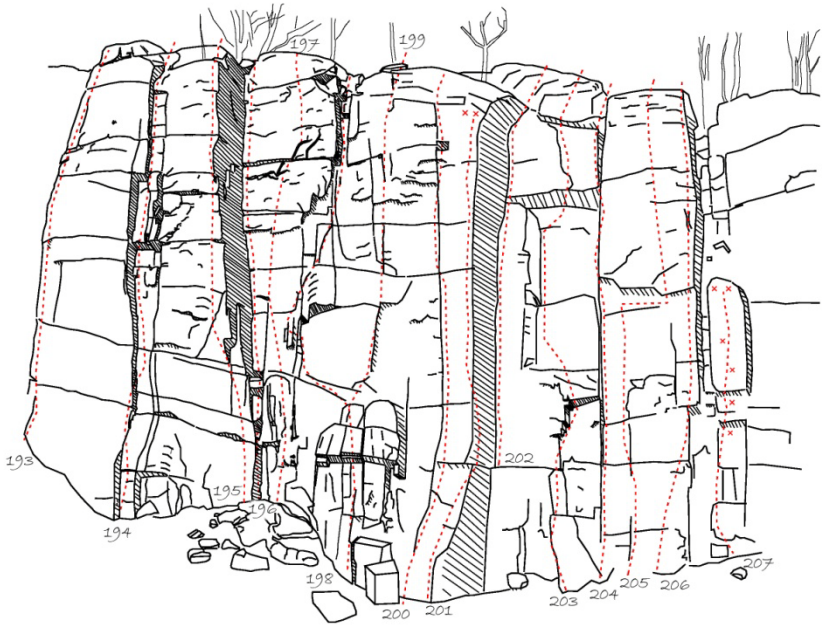
191. Unnamed

Climb the chimney to the top

192. The Hisser 5.4 TR

A short distance uphill and left of Day Tripper. Look for a series of flakes and right facing corners that lead to the top.

Dihedrals Main Face



Historically most of the climbing has probably been done at the dihedrals, but since the train wreck it seems like less has been done there. There are certainly some great climbs to do. Some of the climbs have hangers at the top to make it easy to set up top ropes, including Day Tripper, Twin Cracks and Beast of Burden.

193. Day Tripper 5.11b PG***

According to comments from climbers this is one of the best routes at Little Falls. I have rarely seen it climbed, probably because it is so difficult. The climb goes up the rounded arête defining the left edge of the dihedrals, primarily on the right side (the south face). There are two starts for the first 10 ft, the "direct start" that goes up the south face, and another to the left that is on the curve of the arête or perhaps a little around the curve toward the west face. The direct start is very difficult, the second a little easier.

194. Twin Cracks 5.9 PG**

A Little Falls classic. Sometimes it's a crack climb, other times it's a wide chimney. Two overhangs to get past. Use hand jams, laybacks, stem, wedges, knee locks and other innovative moves.

195. Unnamed

Under development

196. Cotters Corner 5.6 R*

Most everybody's first climb at the dihedrals; my first outdoor climb ever. May be 5.7 but the historical rating is 5.6. To climb in the proper manner, get into the wide crack at the bottom, climb about 12 feet to get where the dihedral/corner begins, and then go straight up the corner crack. Good balance is required. There are at least two variations that make the climb a little easier. At the start, instead of going up the crack move 6 or 8 ft to the right, climb up to the ledge and then drift back left to where the corner begins. The second is about two-thirds of the way up. At a difficult spot in the corner, turn left onto a small ledge and tiptoe left out to arête. Go 5 or 6 ft up the arête and then move back into the corner using some large blocks on the face. This second alternate is wonderful fun with lots of exposure. This climb is almost always top roped; there are trees at the top that make the setup easy.



Micah Coleman demonstrates the proper manner on Twin Cracks.
Photographer unknown.

197. Unnamed

This route is still under development, so the rating is a guess. A neat but difficult face climb. Start like on Cotters Corner, or use the alternate Cotters Corner start off to the right. At the ledge about 12 ft up, instead of going left into Cotters Corner just continue straight up the face, sliding to the right a little about half way up.

198. Freight Train Blues 5.8 PG*

An excellent route that it seems like you can do over and over. Except for the traverse on the ledge this route is pretty much continuous 5.8. Stand up on a couple of big blocks and then use a layback to go over the overhang and grab the edge of the ledge above. Mantle or otherwise get up onto the ledge, move left and then up about 6 ft. Now go left to get around the next overhang (some tricky moves) and then move to the right and on up to the finish chimney. For an easier start of this climb, use the Cotters Corner alternate

start to get up to the ledge. Usually top roped. There are two trees at the top, but they are about 12 ft back from the edge so a static rope or long slings are useful for setting a top rope

199. Desperado 5.11b X**

Follow the previous route. but instead of going left into the chimney climb directly through small overhangs and laybacks to a tiny ledge, then traverse right to a small left facing corner leading to the top.

200. Coffin Crack (A3)

The brilliant, piton scared seamy crack going directly up the middle of the wall. Where it comes to a T, a series of tweekers and laybacks lead to the exit on Desperado. Still yearning to be free.

201. Black Arête 5.12b X***

One of the beautiful arêtes at the dihedrals. A very challenging route, one section is overhanging. Generally stay on the south face, although just after starting you may want to swing around on the east face for a few feet. It was marked to be bolted but didn't get done. The top anchors are in. Hopefully to be finished in 2009.

202. Devils Corner 5.11b PG***

A dihedral, crack, open book or whatever you want to call it. Can be climbed with crack technique, by stemming with the feet up the sides of the book, using laybacks, or an infinitely variable combination of all three. A demanding route however you do it. You will need a static rope to connect a top rope to the trees just back from the top of the cliff.

203. Satans Ceiling 5.10a R**

Stand about halfway between the two crack climbs (Devils Corner and The Devil won't Care) and go right up the face. The crux is getting over the first overhang about 20 ft up; use a layback off the edge at the left side of the overhang. Continue up to the second overhang, lean way out, grab the monster flake above the overhang and try to work your feet up onto the flake. The easiest way to set up a top rope for this climb is by connecting a static rope to the trees just back from the top of the cliff.

204. The Devil won't Care 5.8 G**

Climb the wide crack a few feet to the right of Satans Ceiling. Look for small footholds out on the face or inside the crack. There is a strenuous mantle (or use good footwork) about halfway up to get on the ledge left of the crack. This climb is often led. The same top rope setup used for Satans Ceiling also works on this climb. Many top rope climbers will move to the left to do the spectacular Satans Ceiling second overhang when doing this route.

205. Brittle Traverse 5.8 TR

Climb up a thin crack just right of the previous route. Then about 15 ft off the ground traverse to the right. And then? According to Geoffrey Childs the route continues up the face, but the question is how to do so with 5.8 moves. We usually end up standing on top of the double arête and then sort of following the Beast of Burden route to the top.

206. Beast of Burden 5.10b R

There is a somewhat dirty chimney just to the left of the Double Arête. The junction of the left face of this chimney and the cliff face defines another arête, and this climb goes up it, generally staying a little on the cliff face side. Starting the climb, it is difficult to keep from barn dooring off to the right.

207. The Juicer 5.13a Sport**

Originally named The Double Arête by the climbers that bolted it, but this name is more descriptive. Four bolts to the clip in anchors. Short and oh so challenging! Work your way to the overhang at the bottom of the big protruding block of rock. Reach up and place one hand on each of the vertical edges of this block (the two arêtes) and continue up. Best done on a cool day, as there will probably be no opportunity to chalk up. The last clip is hard to get in position for. To practice on this climb, set up the top rope for Beast of Burden and redirect one strand of the rope through the rightmost clip-in at the top of Juicer.



Bill Griffith practices on The Juicer

208. Blood on the Tracks 5.11c G**

A path leads through dense brush near the highest portion of the pale-colored cliff band right of the Dihedrals. A few meters east of an obvious right-facing corner you will find a beautiful vertical crack. Climb this (15') to a bulging wall where difficult face moves take you to the top. Good climbing; frequently sieged.

209 – 215. Reserved.

NYCE Wall



From the eastern edge of the dihedrals, walk east along the tracks a little less than 100 yards. Turn north and head into the woods. Look for the small wall shown above about 100 ft in. The NYCE wall is on private property, but not on the large private parcel we have been discussing throughout the guide.

216. Local's Trick 5.11 TR

The face left of the buttress on the west side of NYCE rock has been top-roped in modern style. Finish via the obvious crack.

217. NYCE Face 5.12b/c G***

Two bolts in the center of NYCE rock mark this excellent and very demanding line. Though just 35' in length, there is much to ponder on this route. Long reaches and a clever move or two, then after the second bolt go left at the horizontal crack and then up.

218 – 230. Reserved

Dolgeville Railroad ROW Wall



The ROW wall(s) as you approach from the east

I believe this area was named the He Man Slabs in the 1990 guide, but I have renamed it. There are small walls on each side of the railroad ROW. The wall on the north side (right side in the photo) has the better climbing. As of Fall 2008 there are three routes along the north side wall, with hangers at the top for setting a top rope. If you climb to the top of the south wall and walk south a few feet there is a drop off where more climbs might be possible.

To get here, park in the pullout up on highway 5, then walk back west about 200 ft to where the path goes south. Follow the path for about 50 ft until it drops down onto the old ROW. Turn right (west) and walk a couple hundred feet until you come to the cliffs shown above. This wall is on the large private land parcel.